

University of Graz

Research Assessment Reform

CoARA Action Plan 2024 – 2027

Introduction and Overview

The University of Graz joined the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) in autumn 2022. The coalition's core commitments closely align with the university's efforts to reform research assessment. Our guiding principles are to **increase transparency** and **recognize the wide range of activities carried out by academic staff**.

In Austria, universities are responsible for implementing and executing the legal framework for research evaluation. The University of Graz has steadily improved its evaluation procedures, which are currently undergoing reform to adapt to the current challenges in the international higher education landscape, such as avoiding the inappropriate use of metrics, recognizing the diversity of contributions and valuing quality and impact over quantity.

The reform has the potential to initiate a cultural change – towards recognition of a broad range of activities, competence orientation and development opportunities for employees. This cultural shift is a significant challenge. It is necessary because while quantitative methods are familiar, they do not provide a complete picture of all achievements of researchers. Qualitative assessment methods on the other hand are able to provide a more comprehensive understanding of such achievements. The big concern amongst various stakeholders is that qualitative assessment methods are more burdensome, not easily comparable and more difficult to assess. Support and training are crucial in countering this issue and in demonstrating the value of qualitative assessment approaches. The success of this research assessment reform depends on the commitment of the university management to this reform, the acceptance of the new modalities by the employees and the cooperation of the university units in the development and implementation.

The reform is led by the Vice Rector for Research and it is carried out in close cooperation with the whole Rectorate, the Senate, the Deans of the Faculties and the administrative departments.

Research Assessment and its Reform

Status quo

Research evaluation of units: Research evaluation procedures are part of the University's

quality management system and contribute to the management of the University's planning and decision-making processes. Academic research units and departments are evaluated at least every seven years, with a focus on development and profiling, optimisation and improvement.

The procedure is flexible and differentiated, taking into account the research culture of each unit to be evaluated. Evaluation criteria and data collection are tailored to the unit's specialisation and focus. Stakeholders in the units being evaluated are actively encouraged to contribute and take ownership throughout the evaluation process. In many cases, external evaluators are brought in to review the evaluation.

Research Evaluation of units

uniform, but subject-specific process, which comprises the following stages:

- Narrative self-evaluation, including strategic orientation and attention to third-mission efforts
- Peer visit and peer review
- Implementation workshop

The objectives are:

- Reflection on research/research performance
- Support/impulse to further develop the research profile and strengthen the scientific impact
- Further development through assessment by international peers
- Improvement of the promotion of young researchers
- Exchange and understanding within the university

Professorial appointment procedures: The University of Graz will hire highly qualified and promising scientists to strengthen its position in a wide range of research fields of strategic importance. Educating students and training early-career researchers is a responsibility that the University of Graz takes seriously. The university has developed a highly effective appointment procedure that takes into account candidates' varying career levels. The procedure evaluates not only research, but also teaching, training, attention to gender equality and societal engagement.

The staff appraisal is an essential tool for personnel development at the University. It allows for exchange of information between employees and their supervisors in a confidential setting. It provides an opportunity for feedback and the shaping of personal development plans.

Research Reform

A detailed analysis and description of the evaluation landscape at the University of Graz was carried out in the Work package “Alternative Research Assessment” of the Arqus R.I. H2020 project. Furthermore, we internally explored international models and approaches for evaluating research. During this process, two core instruments were developed: the Research Fora and the Activity Framework. Both instruments prioritize quality and impact, consider a broad range of academic activities, involve stakeholders and align with CoARA. The Activity Framework is designed to address the individual level, while Research Fora are intended to facilitate discussion and development at the organizational level. Both of these tools are currently in the process of testing and further development.

Activity Framework: The Activity framework is an alternative form of assessment that outlines the expectations placed on scientists at different career stages. Through working groups that include employees from all career levels, discipline-specific items for the Activity Framework are developed at a “Pilot Faculty”. The items developed are coordinated with the relevant administrative departments to determine if the necessary background information is available or needs to be gathered. The goal is to develop a catalog of criteria and corresponding values for each career level which are presented in a structured report for evaluation by management or a committee (peers). A university-wide implementation will take place in stages. The first faculty will start in 2024. Other faculties will follow successively.

Activity Framework

Transparency on the achievements expected at the respective career level and research culture

- activities in research and research funding
- promotion of early-stage researchers
- teaching achievements and innovations
- societal engagement / outreach activities
- management performance and transferable skills

Guidance and support in evaluation and appointment procedures, resource allocation, incentives, monitoring the performance

The objective is for the individual to gain an awareness of the expectations placed on academics at their respective career stage, with the intention of developing accordingly. A second objective is to distribute resources fairly and transparently on the basis of their performances.

The **research fora**, successfully piloted at the Faculty of Natural Sciences, are an alternative form of research evaluation at our university and are now set to roll out to other faculties in accordance with rectorate and faculty management. The goal is to increase research performance and visibility of research at the University of Graz in accordance with the CoARA principles. They are envisioned as a continuous, inclusive, proactive and bottom-up process along discussion events in order to work out and bring to life a vision and strategy for the different branches of science. Feedback from the pilot is very positive and department heads especially valued the direct involvement of the rector and the possibility to present to him.

Research Fora

- Bottom-up, proactive, flexible and continuous process
- shaping a department's vision/strategy
- with possibility to replace traditional format of evaluation

Format for research units to internally discuss topics centered around: innovative research, impact within scientific community and the society, international visibility.

Outcome: strategy document on the development for the next ten years

- Maintaining and improving the performance and visibility of research at the University of Graz
- Increasing the attractiveness of the University of Graz for professors and Early-Stage Researchers to be appointed

The research assessment reform is included in the university's strategic documents. The status of the research assessment reform, the core commitments of CoARA and case studies from other universities that have successfully reformed research assessment will be presented at an event. Regarding the Activity Framework, staff, and especially supervisors and management, will be provided with comprehensive training on how to effectively use the Activity Framework in staff appraisals. All employees are provided with informational materials and receive continuous updates on the Activity Framework.

We disseminate best practices through workshops, training sessions, events, regular exchanges with partner universities in a "Task Force on Alternative Research Assessment" and contributions to CoARA working groups. At "Universities Austria" and other national forums, we will be carefully considering and addressing the important issue of reforming research assessment.

Core Commitments & Actions

Commitment	State	Modification/adaption/action	Timeframe
1. Recognise the diversity of contributions to- and careers in- research, in accordance with the needs and nature of the research	- research information system contains data on networking, outreach and activities for a wider audience; - outreach activities and teaching are partly included in the research evaluation of departments/research branches and at the individual level as well, for example in the context of requirement profiles and qualification agreements;	- Research Fora (RF) will be held; - Activity Framework (AF) will be developed; → both focusing on impact and quality, under consideration of a broad range of activities; - AF: adaption and implementation of new activities in the existing research information system; - launch of a personal profile page on the activities in the AF (a page with customizable settings); ----- - CoARA Working Group: Working Group on Reforming Academic Career Assessment (ACA);	- RF as of November 2022 at pilot faculty as alternative to research evaluation - from 2024 on at other faculties. ----- - AF pilot as of September 2023 - development of items 2024 - data and information availability check in parallel in 2024 - step-by-step implementation as of 01 2025 2nd half of 2024 start in other faculties
2. Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators	- internal and external peer reviewers in research evaluation; - appointment procedures: peer reviewers and responsible use of a set of bibliometric indicators; h-index is avoided, if someone is requesting it, he/she will be informed about its shortcomings;	- AF: the catalog of activities is intended to serve as a basis for development discussions and to support the fair allocation of resources; ----- - RF predominantly along qualitative indicators, a discussion-oriented approach using workshops; ----- - conduct evaluations without internal peer reviewers	- AF: exact evaluation process will be developed until Q3 25 ----- - RF, see above ----- - from 2025 on external peer reviewers/experts

3. Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication- based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index	see above	- ongoing information about responsible metrics; - peers can be included on a voluntary basis;	ongoing
4. Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment	rankings of research organisations are not used in research assessment; only data of highly cited publications from the Leiden Ranking in combination with further indicators and other background information are used;	no modification	no additional actions in the period of 2023-2027
5. Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to	- resources for the disciplines/departments to hold workshops in the context of RF are available; - experts (peers) engaged in the RF are remunerated (unit level); - direct involvement of rector and vice rector in RF; - position for the coordination of the RF funded; - position for research evaluation funded;	funding of one position for coordinating the Activity Framework;	AF: as of Q3 2024
6. Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes	continuous review of research assessment: (FINEEC Quality Audit, Arqus R.I. Alternative Assessment; Task force on Alternative Research Assessment (TF), CoARA WG ACA);	AF: participation of the whole organisation (management, administration, researchers from all career levels);	ongoing

7. Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use	• RF event 2022 in pilot faculty; • meetings of the working group AF; • workshops with rectorate;	• research assessment reform event (CoARA, RF, AF); • trainings and workshops, university-wide discussion event/communication, handbooks	• RF: pilot event: Nov 2022 • RF: one event planned per participating faculty.
			• university-wide discussion event Q4 2024 • austrian-wide research assessment reform event: 04 2024 (in preparation) • AF: trainings and workshops as of Q4 2024
8. Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition	• ongoing national and international exchange (Arqus, Universities Austria, CoARA, EUA);	• CoARA Coalition and Working Group; • Task Force Alternative Research Assessment (TF);	• Task Force on Research Assessment (TF) as of November 2023 • CoARA Working group: Reforming Academic Career Assessment
9. Communicate progress made on adherence to the principles and implementation of the Commitments	-	• Research Assessment Action Plan is published on Zenodo and University website • active communication of Research Assessment Reform;	• Action Plan published: Q3 2024 • ongoing
10. Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research	• ongoing evaluation and examination with research on research;	• ongoing evaluation and analysis and consideration of research on research; • active participation in CoARA activities;	• ongoing monitoring